

LIVE



NEWSPAPER 16th November, 2017

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

46th WEEK



LEBANON... ANOTHER CHESSBOARD

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II... EFFECT OF POLICIES AND POLITICS OF DEVELOPING COUNTRIES ON INDIA'S INTERESTS.



Learning Space

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NEWSPAPER EDITORIALS ... DISCUSSION

16th NOVEMBER, 2017

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The Hariri mystery

The Lebanese PM must return from Saudi Arabia lest his country slides into chaos

Saudi Arabia's short resignation as Lebanon's Prime Minister has not just plunged the country into an 'other side of politics' but also into a chaotic regional situation. Lebanon has been a theatre for proxy regional battles for years. Eleven months ago, Mr. Hariri, a Sunni with close business and political ties with Saudi Arabia, had formed a coalition with Hezbollah, a Shia party committed to Iran's support. This, in turn, allowed the election of Michel Aoun as Lebanon's President. But since then Riyadh has become increasingly impatient with Mr. Hariri's failure to confront Hezbollah, whose militia wing was involved in the Syrian civil war on behalf of President Bashar al-Assad, another Saudi ally. It was against this backdrop that Mr. Hariri announced his resignation on November 4 from the Saudi kingdom. He had been in Saudi Arabia for his resignation, so that the coalition can take the next steps. His continued absence has triggered speculation that he was forced by the Saudis to resign and is being held in custody against his will at a time when the kingdom is turning up the heat on Hezbollah and Iran.

There are regional stakes involved in this situation. Hezbollah has evolved into a battle-hardened semi-conventional military force. In 2006, Israel attacked Lebanon with the aim of destroying Hezbollah, with little success. Since then, Hezbollah has amassed weapons from Iran and has got itself embroiled in the Syrian civil war. Its political arm has enormous influence in Beirut's corridors of power. Saudi Arabia is concerned about its growing military and political clout, which it sees as an Iranian proxy. US President Donald Trump has backed Saudi policies. Riyadh has the strong support of Israel, which sees Hezbollah as a threat to its north-east border. If the Saudis forced Mr. Hariri to resign, they will put an end to Saudi Arabia's tolerance of Hezbollah's regional role. Saudi Arabia has also asked its citizens to leave Lebanon, signalling potential military action. Hezbollah, given its capabilities and history of resistance, may retaliate if its moderateists come under attack. It is unfortunate that Lebanon is once again becoming a proxy in the West Asian geopolitical chessboard. Lebanon's leaders, who will recall the horrors of the 1975-1990 civil war, should forge at least a semblance of unity and bring end powers to stay out of the country's internal politics. They should ask Mr. Hariri to return home immediately and explain to the people the real reasons behind his resignation, and why he announced it from Riyadh. Hezbollah should also be ready to address the concerns of its coalition partners and be wary of disrupting the political balance. Stability in Lebanon will give the region a boost.

THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

Date : 15th November, 2017

1 The Hariri mystery

THE HINDU
INDIA'S NATIONAL NEWSPAPER SINCE 1878

Date :15th November, 2017

The Lebanese PM must return from Saudi Arabia lest his country slides into instability

Saad Hariri's shock resignation as Lebanon's Prime Minister has not just plunged the country into another spell of political instability but also reignited regional tensions between Saudi Arabia and Iran. Lebanon has been a theatre for proxy regional battles for years. Eleven months ago, Mr. Hariri, a Sunni with close business and political ties with Saudi Arabia, had formed a coalition with Hezbollah, a Shia party-cum-militia that has Iran's support. This had, in turn, allowed the election of Michel Aoun as Lebanon's President. But since then Riyadh has become increasingly impatient with Mr. Hariri's failure to confront Hezbollah, whose militia wing was involved in the Syrian civil war on behalf of President Bashar al-Assad, another Saudi rival. It was against this backdrop that Mr. Hariri announced his resignation on November 4 from the Saudi capital and blamed Hezbollah and Iran for his decision. Surprisingly, more than a week later he is yet to return to Lebanon and complete the formalities of the resignation, so that the coalition can take the next steps. His continued absence has triggered speculation that he was forced by the Saudis to resign and is being held in Riyadh against his will at a time when the kingdom is turning up the heat on Hezbollah and Iran.

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1 The Hariri mystery

...Contd.

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There are regional stakes involved in this situation. Hezbollah has evolved into a battle-hardened semi-conventional military force. In 2006, Israel attacked Lebanon with the aim of destroying Hezbollah, with little success. Since then, Hezbollah has amassed weapons from Iran and has got battlefield training in the Syrian civil war. Its political arm has enormous influence in Beirut's corridors of power. Saudi Arabia is concerned about this growing military and political clout of what it sees as an Iranian proxy. U.S. President Donald Trump has backed Saudi policies. Riyadh has the silent support of Israel, which sees Hezbollah as a threat on its northern border. If the Saudis forced Mr. Hariri to resign, they will prefer another Sunni leader who takes a more confrontational view of Hezbollah. Saudi Arabia has also asked its citizens to leave Lebanon, signalling potential military action. Hezbollah, given its capabilities and history of resistance, may retaliate if its core interests come under attack. It is unfortunate that Lebanon is once again becoming a pawn on the West Asian geopolitical chessboard. Lebanon's leaders, who will recall the horrors of the 1975-1990 civil war, should forge at least a semblance of unity and ask regional powers to stay out of the country's domestic politics. They should ask Mr. Hariri to return home immediately and explain to the people the real reasons behind his resignation, and why he announced it from Riyadh. Hezbollah should also be ready to address the concerns of its coalition partners and be wary of disrupting the political balance. Nobody in Lebanon will gain if this balance is upset.



ABOUT LEBANON

- High Literacy Rate
- Known for traditional mercantile culture
- Important commercial hub for the Middle East
- Shia Muslims, Sunni Muslims, Christians and Druze are the main groups.
- Population 6 million
- Major language Arabic
- Life Expectancy 78 years for men and 81 years for women.



SYRIA

Cyprus

LEBANON

IRAQ

Mediterranean Sea

ISRAEL

WEST BANK

JORDAN

EGYPT

SAUDI ARABIA

Gulf of Aqaba



TURKEY

SYRIA

IRAQ

JORDAN

Israel

KUWAIT

Cyprus

BEIRUT
LEBANON

Mediterranean Sea

Gulf of Aqaba

THREE LEADERS...THREE GROUPS



MICHEL AOUN
PRESIDENT, LEBANON

He was elected by Parliament in October 2016. He is the Founder of Maronite Christian political Party, the Free Patriotic Movement



SAAD HARIRI (RESIGNED)
PRIME MINISTER, LEBANON

He is a Sunni Muslim Leader and a Businessman. He was nominated to form a Government by the President Aoun in November 2016. He is Sunni Muslim born in Saudi Arabia and spent much of the life there. He got construction company Saudi Oger in Saudi Arabia. One of the Lebanon's richest individuals.



HASSAN NASRALLAH

It is Lebanese political and paramilitary party based in Lebanon. It represents Shia Islam. Hezbollah is the proxy for Iran. It is primarily funded by Iran. Speaker of the Parliament of Lebanon is from this group

WHAT IS THIS DELICATE POWER BALANCE?



MICHEL AOUN



**SAAD HARIRI
(RESIGNED)**



NABIH BERRI

Speaker of the Parliament of Lebanon

Overall, the situation in Lebanon is highly delicate.

- 1** Lebanese Prime Minister is Sunni, the President is Maronite Christian and Parliamentary Speaker is Shia.
- 2** After the 1975-1990 civil war, peace has largely been held.
- 3** Hezbollah championed the Shias and Christians sought to protect their interests.
- 4** But, friction increased in recent years as more than a million, mainly Sunni refugees from Syria poured into the Country
- 5** Hezbollah is fully supported by Iran and it is not that easy for Saudi Arabia to weaken Hezbollah.
- 6** If Saudi Arabia takes direct measures against Lebanon, then Sunnis, Christians, Druze will also be affected badly.



HEZBOLLAH
POLITICAL PARTY

Some Lebanese consider Hezbollah a threat to the country's stability, but it is enduringly popular within the Shia community.

HEZBOLLAH

- 1 It is the Shia Islamic political military Organisation.
- 2 It wields considerable power in Lebanon.
- 3 It emerged with the help of Iran during the Israeli occupation of Lebanon in the early 1990s.
- 4 Its ideological roots stretches back to the Shia Islamic revival in Lebanon in 1960s and 1970s
- 5 Israel withdrew from Lebanon in 2000, but Hezbollah resisted the pressure to disarm and continued to strengthen its military wing.
- 6 It became a key power broker in the Lebanon's political system,

RECENT DEVELOPMENTS



SAAD HARIRI (RESIGNED)
PRIME MINISTER, LEBANON

- 1 Saudi Arabia intervention in Lebanon is quite evident. It is to disturb the delicate power balance and also to undermine Iranian backed Hezbollah.
- 2 Saudi is working with US and Israel to isolate the group.
- 3 Lebanese Prime Minister Saad Hariri was made to resign from Saudi Arabia. He says that he feared his life.
- 4 Lebanon is caught between regional sectorial rivalry between Iran and Saudi Arabia.
- 5 Saudi Arabia says that Hezbollah is engaging in other countries.
- 6 Now, Saudi Arabia advised its citizens to leave Lebanon.



HEZBOLLAH
POLITICAL PARTY



LEBANON...ANOTHER CHESS BOARD FOR VARIOUS PLAYERS

- 1 Hezbollah is supported by Iran to extend its influence.
- 2 Israel does not want Hezbollah in its backyard.
- 3 In 2006, Israel attacked Lebanon with the aim of destroying Hezbollah, but met with little success.
- 4 Hezbollah leads enormous powers in Lebanon.
- 5 Saudi Arabia is concerned about this growing military and political clout of Hezbollah
- 6 Now, the Saudi Arabia has got the direct support of Donald Trump



SAAD HARIRI (RESIGNED)
PRIME MINISTER, LEBANON

Hariri should return home immediately. Hezbollah should be ready to address the concerns of its coalition. Nobody in Lebanon will gain, if this balance is upset.

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SINCERE THANKS
FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

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